Tamil Sangam and editor of the scholarly Tamil monthly, *Vivekabhanu*, and a friend of VOC, went to Salem accompanied by a local Tamil pandit, Nataraja Aiyar, and canvassed for shares.[100] He also canvassed in Coimbatore, Palghat and Calicut. So involved was he that, during these heady days, he even left the business of running *Vivekabhanu* to his associate.[101]

Apart from enthusiastic volunteers, SSNCo also used paid agents—on a retainer of about Rs 20–25 plus travelling expenses—to canvass for shares.[102] One Kalyanasundaram Aiyar, who accompanied Pandithurai Thevar on his July 1907 Thanjavur visit, and distributed share application forms and prospectus is one such example. He was the person who succeeded in selling shares to Abraham Pandithar and K.S. Srinivasa Pillai.[103] He visited Thanjavur again in October to canvass for more shares.[104]

Duraiswamy Aiyar, a thirty-year-old post-office clerk at Kallibada, Coorg, fed up with the racism rampant in the coffee plantations of the area, resigned in protest and joined SSNCo on a monthly salary of Rs 20. He spoke at public meetings to win shareholders.[105]

P. Somasundaram Mudaliar/Pillai, a petty broker in the cotton trade, with interest in Swadeshi matters, was a sub-agent (or working agent as he called himself). He was to canvass for shares but, unable to collect the money himself, he directed prospective shareholders to remit the money by post to SSNCo using the share application forms attested by him. It is through an interesting police interception that he comes to our notice. P. Somasundaram Mudaliar/Pillai wrote to the secretary of India Steam Navigation Company in Moulmein, Burma. The letter drew attention to ‘the strength of patriotism’ in India and suggested that this should be tapped to encourage industry. Apparently, he had earlier proposed to establish a Swadeshi sugar and fibre manufacturing company but had failed when the promoter passed away. He was now suggesting that the addressee should start a new company called the Madras Steam Navigation Company, promising to collect at least 5,000 shares of Rs 25 each. The idea was to